EMPLOYEE EXPERIENCE

How Do You Make Company Knowledge Useful Beyond One Person?

Capture the conditions behind an answer so another employee can use it responsibly.

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Useful company knowledge explains what to do, when the answer applies, which source supports it, and who maintains it. Recording a long conversation with an experienced colleague can preserve information. It does not automatically produce something another employee can find, understand, and trust during a task.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Begin with a recurring task rather than a knowledge-base project.
- Separate retrieval from professional judgment.
- Test finding an answer and applying it correctly.

Where should you start when knowledge depends on one employee?

Start with a recurring task or decision that people bring to that employee. Observe which details they request, which sources they use, and what makes them qualify an answer. Capture those conditions as well as the conclusion so another person can recognize when the guidance applies.

Separate factual retrieval from professional judgment. A current document can answer where a price list is stored. A technical exception may still require an authorized specialist.

What should a useful company knowledge entry contain?

Include a recognizable question, short answer, applicable conditions, supporting source, owner, and update trigger. The NATA Knowledge Use Record below organizes those elements. The reader should be able to identify the next action and know when the answer does not apply without reading an entire conversation.

Element	A practical test
Task or question	Would an employee recognize the situation from its wording?
Answer	Can they identify the next action without reading everything?
Conditions	Can they tell whether the answer applies to this case?
Source	Can they find the governing document or decision?
Owner	Is someone responsible for correcting the record?
Review trigger	What change could make the answer wrong?

Use examples only where they clarify application. Avoid treating a specific project's exception as a company-wide rule.

Where should employees find operational knowledge?

Place guidance near the task where it is needed and use the language employees recognize. Link from the working record where practical. A person preparing a quote should not have to recall the exact name of an onboarding document before discovering which instruction or product reference is current.

Nielsen Norman Group identifies recognition rather than recall as a usability principle. Applied here, the record should help an employee recognize the relevant situation rather than remember the exact name of a document they once saw.

A link from the working record may be more useful than a new folder hierarchy. Test the path the employee actually takes.

How do you preserve exceptions without making guidance confusing?

Explain the distinction that changes the next action instead of turning one project's condition into a company-wide rule. In an illustrative supplier case, a confirmed specification may be required for a firm quote while preliminary budget guidance remains possible. The knowledge entry should help the employee recognize both routes.

A knowledge entry that says "specification required" may block that conversation. An entry that distinguishes a firm quote from preliminary guidance allows the employee to identify the right route and escalate when necessary. The record preserves the reasoning boundary rather than pretending to replace expertise.

How do you test whether company knowledge is actually usable?

Ask an employee to locate the answer for a realistic scenario, explain why it applies, and describe the next action. Finding the document and applying it correctly are separate tests. Record hesitation and assumptions to improve the entry or workflow, rather than testing memory of the founder's preferred terminology.

Record where they hesitate and which assumptions they make. Update the entry or the surrounding workflow accordingly. Do not turn the exercise into a memory test or an assessment of how well someone knows the founder.

How do you keep a knowledge base current?

Assign an owner and connect updates to changes in products, policies, suppliers, systems, or responsibilities. Use periodic review where appropriate, but do not wait for a review date after a governing rule changes. Distinguish archived guidance from the current source while retaining history according to company rules.

Archived records should be distinguishable from current guidance. Deleting the history entirely can also remove context needed to understand past decisions, so retention should follow the company's rules.

Success means more people can complete the task with an appropriate answer and know when to seek judgment. The experienced colleague remains valuable. Their availability stops being the only way to discover how the business works.

Frequently asked questions

Should you record every conversation with an expert?

Start with recurring tasks and decisions where another person needs usable guidance. A complete archive may preserve information while making it harder to find the relevant answer. The record should serve the task.

Can an AI search tool replace the knowledge owner?

Retrieval does not establish whether guidance is current or applicable. Someone still needs responsibility for the source, its limits, updates, and the cases that require specialist judgment.

What should happen to outdated knowledge entries?

Clearly distinguish them from current guidance and link to the replacement where appropriate. Retain history according to company rules so past decisions can still be understood without confusing today's user.

SOURCES & CASE BASIS

This guide presents a working method, not measured client results. Examples are illustrative unless explicitly attributed. Sources linked in the text support the stated principle or published example; they do not validate the NATA worksheet as an assessed instrument. Prepared and revised November 4, 2026; unpublished editorial review draft.